A. General Information

Information Requested	**Information provided by the PI**
1. **Heritage Craft Name**	*Phulkari*
2. **Affiliated Institute**	*Dr. B. R. Ambedkar National Institute of Technology Jalandhar*
3. **Principal Investigators**	*Dr Priyanka Gupta (PI), Dr Monica Sikka (Co-PI), Dr Anu H. Gupta (Co-PI)*
4. **Official Project Title**	*Revitalizing Phulkari: A Textile Science Approach to Documentation, Preservation, and Innovation of Traditional Embroidery Techniques*

1. Introduction

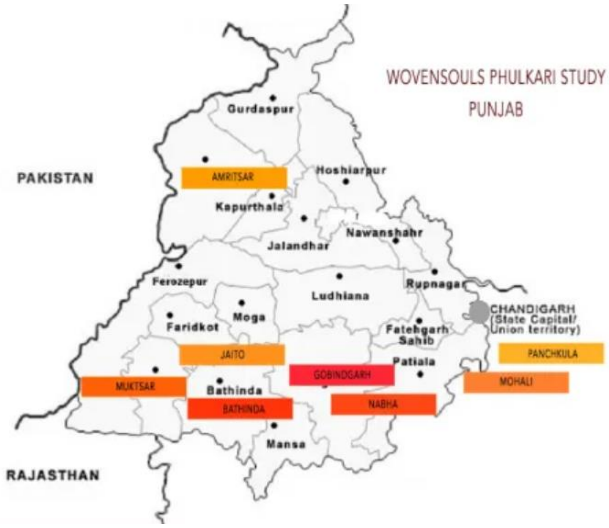
· Brief description of the textile product

Phulkari, particularly in the form of a dupatta (headscarf) or chadar (ceremonial shawl), is a traditional hand-embroidered art form from Punjab. It gained prominence in the 15th century and flourished notably during the time of Maharaja Ranjit Singh. Commonly worn on special occasions such as weddings, festivals, and religious ceremonies, it is admired for its vibrant floral motifs and intricate stitching techniques. Often described as “flower work,” it reflects patterns of flowers, leaves, and geometric designs that define its unique aesthetic. Traditionally crafted using silk threads on cotton or khadi fabric, it has been closely associated with women’s attire. Passed down through generations, this art form represents both creative expression and shared cultural heritage. It holds deep cultural, social, and economic significance in the region, symbolizing community traditions while showcasing local beliefs and practices. Additionally, it continues to provide a valuable source of livelihood and financial support for many families.

· Geographical area of production (map if possible)

Phulkari is traditionally produced in the broader Punjab cultural region, which historically included areas of both present-day Punjab and Punjab. Before the Partition of India, important centers of Phulkari embroidery were spread across districts such as Amritsar, Ludhiana, Jalandhar, and Patiala in India, as well as Lahore, Rawalpindi, Multan, and Sialkot in Pakistan. This shows that Phulkari belongs to the wider Punjabi cultural belt rather than being confined to modern political boundaries. In present-day India, its production is mainly concentrated in regions of Punjab including Patiala, Amritsar, Jalandhar, Ludhiana, Bathinda, and Hoshiarpur. With its recognition under Geographical Indication (GI), the craft is also practiced in neighboring areas of Haryana and parts of Rajasthan. Overall, the geographical spread of Phulkari reflects the agrarian and cultural

landscape of Punjab, where it originated and continues to thrive as a traditional embroidery form.



- Key characteristics (material, technique, motifs, end-use)

Material: Phulkari is traditionally made on handwoven cotton fabric known as *khaddar*, which provides a coarse yet durable base. The embroidery is done using brightly colored silk floss thread called *pat*, typically worked on the reverse side of the fabric to create a smooth, satin-like finish on the front.

Technique: The craft is entirely hand-embroidered using a distinctive darning stitch. Artisans work from the back of the fabric, counting threads to create precise and intricate patterns without pre-drawn designs. This technique gives phulkari its characteristic geometric precision and textured appearance.

Motifs: Phulkari features vibrant and symbolic motifs inspired by nature and daily life, including flowers, leaves, crops, animals, and geometric patterns. The term “phulkari” itself means “flower work,” reflecting the dominance of floral designs. These motifs often carry cultural and emotional meanings, representing prosperity, fertility, and spirituality.

End-use: Traditionally, phulkari is used in garments such as dupattas and shawls, especially for weddings, festivals, and religious ceremonies. It is an essential part of bridal trousseaus. In contemporary contexts, it is also adapted into a variety of products like sarees, suits, stoles, home furnishings, and accessories, blending traditional craftsmanship with modern utility.

- **Why is it classified as a *textile heritage***

Phulkari is classified as a textile heritage due to its deep-rooted cultural and historical significance. It has ancient origins, with the craft traditionally passed down from mother to daughter, preserving skills and knowledge across generations. The embroidery serves as a vivid expression of community life, reflecting the rural lifestyle of Punjab along with its beliefs, values, and emotions.

As a handcrafted textile art, phulkari is entirely created by hand using silk floss (pat) on handwoven cotton fabric (khaddar), highlighting the dedication and craftsmanship involved. It also plays an important role in social traditions, being an essential part of wedding trousseaus and various ceremonies. Furthermore, phulkari symbolizes regional identity and pride, representing the cultural heritage of Punjab while contributing to the diversity of India's traditional arts. Its importance has also been formally recognized through preservation efforts, including the granting of Geographical Indication (GI) status, which helps protect and promote this unique craft.

Group of Punjabi Ladies, Circa 1905(Clifton and Co., Bombay)

PHOTOGRAPHS FROM HISTORY

- Cultural and traditional significance

Phulkari, as a heritage craft of Punjab, represents generations of cultural knowledge passed down from mother to daughter, preserving familial and community traditions. It reflects the social and emotional fabric of Punjabi life through its vibrant motifs and symbolic patterns inspired by nature, daily life, and spiritual beliefs. Traditionally an essential part of a woman's life—especially in rural areas—phulkari holds deep significance in weddings, festivals, and ceremonies, often forming a meaningful part of bridal trousseaus. Beyond its decorative value, it symbolizes community identity, regional pride, and cultural continuity, while also supporting livelihoods, particularly for rural women. Overall, phulkari stands as a timeless expression of Punjab's heritage, blending tradition, artistry, and social significance.

- Current market presence (local/national/export)

Phulkari embroidery has a multi-level market presence today, ranging from local rural markets to international exports shows a growing but niche international presence. At the local level, Phulkari is widely sold in village fairs, local markets, and handicraft exhibitions across Punjab. It is mainly

produced by rural women artisans and sold through small shops, self-help groups, and cooperatives. Government initiatives and exhibitions (such as khadi and handicraft fairs) also provide direct market access to artisans and help increase local sales. At the national level, Phulkari has gained strong popularity across India as a traditional and fashionable textile. It is sold in major cities through government emporiums, designer stores, and online platforms. At the international (export) level, Phulkari has a growing global demand, especially in countries like the United States, Canada, UAE, and parts of Europe. Although export volumes are still relatively small, government initiatives like "One District One Product" are actively promoting Phulkari for international trade by improving quality and market linkages.

Key Indicators of Phulkari Exports from World

Export Shipments	Importing Countries	Exporting Countries	Buyers	Exporters
1,614	47	4	582	237

Global Import Trade data of Phulkari And Hsn Code 6214

2 Import Shipments found from 1 importing Countries

Date	HSN	Product Description	Origin	Destination	Qty.	Price
17-May-2024	62149090000	1 PCE COTTON MADE PHULKARI	India	Philippines	1 UNT	$29.9
View Complete Bill of Lading with Buyers and Suppliers Names						
25-Jul-2022	62149090000	1 100% COTTON PHULKARI	India	Philippines	1 Piece	$1.8

Between October 2023 and September 2024, a total of 229 Phulkari shipments were exported worldwide, indicating steady demand in the global handicrafts market. Notably, in September 2024 alone, 44 shipments were recorded, reflecting a recent surge in export activity. The major importing countries are the United States, which accounts for about 61% of total imports, followed by Canada with 16%, and Australia with 6%, showing that demand is concentrated largely in countries with a strong South Asian diaspora. In terms of exports, India dominates the global market with 1,607 shipments, making it the leading exporter of Phulkari products. Other exporters include the United Kingdom with 4 shipments and China with 2 shipments, though their contributions remain minimal. Overall, the data highlights India's dominant role in Phulkari exports and the increasing international demand, especially in Western markets.

2. History

· Origin of the craft (region/community)

Though the exact origin of Phulkari is unknown but it is believed that it shows similarity with various forms of embroidery from Pakistan, Afghanistan, Persia etc.Gulkari (Gul meaning flower and kari indicates work) is a floral embroidery from Persia that shows distinct resemblance to Phulkari. Within India, this embroidery shows resemblance with many other embroideries like Kasuti of Karnataka, Heer Bharat and Soof of Gujarat. The founder of Sikhism, Guru Nanak Dev (A.D. 1469- 1538) in his recitations gives prominence to embroidery and regards it as an integral part of feminine duty. He recites in his scriptures - "Kadh kasida pahreh choli tan tu jane nari" implying that a woman establishes her feminine identity only when she knows how to embroider her own costumes. Historically, embroidery was perpetuated and formed as a part of social rituals. Wearing of symbolic phulkari embroidered odhini (head scarf) by the women of the household was part of the rites de passage of the Punjabi household. It was this ritual component that sustained the historical tradition of embroidery. Phulkari was always a domestic craft and never prepared to be sold in the market. It was made with love for the loved ones. It is used during various wedding ceremonies The skill of the bride was judged by the number of Phulkaris and Baghs in her trousseau and most importantly the affluence of her family and the women who trained her.

· Historical development

Phulkaris and *Baghs* that a bride acquired as a part of her trousseau - the number and the heaviness of embroidery, was a reflection of bride's talent and the training she received from her mother. Even financial status was reflected through the intricacy and amount of silk floss used in embroidering *Phulkari*. The maternal mother, grandmother used to take special pains, care, interest, attention and pride in embroidering the same. Punjabi girl from an early age had also to work on it, which showed her skill, creativity and hard work representing her eligibility as bride.
With the coming of the colonial appreciation of *Phulkari* embroidery, also came the decline of *Phulkari* embroidery for personal and ceremonial purposes. *Phulkari* was taken by the British to various exhibitions not for exhibiting the rich tradition of embroidery popular in both East and West Punjab in pre-partition India, but also with the intent to explore its commercial viability in the International market. Prior to its commercialization in the colonial era, women embroidered as a leisure activity, but now demands of the market and revenue generated from its sale reduced it to a routine affair to be pursued under pressures of deadlines and for an unknown customer.
Other factors responsible for the decline of this form of embroidery in the rural hinterland of Punjab was the arrival of cotton fabric and embroidery thread from Europe. Promotion of machine made textiles to local populations in Punjab at cheaper rates also contributed to the steady decline of the hand embroidery on cotton. Largely poor women earning some money for their survival

now embroidered *Phulkari*. Many women started selling fine quality embroidered pieces that they had either inherited or embroidered to traders for what they believed was a profit.

Further ruination of the craft came with the partition of India. The craft of *Phulkari* almost went into oblivion during the independence struggle. Punjab witnessed ethnic strife and communal violence and division of not only territories but also traditions and handicrafts. Sensitive to this decline, several connoisseurs of craft made efforts to revive the tradition in Post-Independent India. *Phulkaris* and *Baghs* were confined to the old trunks, brought out occasionally to air or to be sold in times of dire need to vendors. Light weight and finely woven fabrics like organdie, chiffon, georgette or machine made polyester, rayon and wool with machine embroidery flooded Indian markets. Spinning at home along with the spinning wheel was gradually confined to the realm of history with its symbolic revocation with freedom movement and Gandhi.

Exigencies of livelihood and waning interest in the commercial value of *Phulkari* also affected the traditional methods of teaching of craft from one generation to another. Revivalist insisted on original form wanting the embroidery to be done only on *Khaddar* with silken floss thread (*Pat*) from the wrong side of the cloth by counting of threads. There were few traditional hands available to meet this expectation. Designers from India and abroad bought old *Phulkari* and *Baghs* from vendors at a pittance and cut these into pieces and re-embellished them in their designer outfits without acknowledging its original form or its ethnicity.

- Major transformations over time (materials, techniques, designs)

The process of reviving *Phulkari* brought a perceptive change in the choice of fabrics being used for embroidery in the middle of the twentieth century. It was a consequence of multiple factors that included affordability, convenience of embroidery and changing fashion trends. In the first phase of commoditization of this style of embroidery in the colonial period,gradual substitution of fabric happened. Innovations in its usage from a traditional wrap to bedspreads, curtains, cushion covers to ladies shawls38 and coats required experimentation with the fabric too. Convenience of embroidering on *Khaddar* restricted commercial production on other fabrics. Over the years as the embroidery moved in the mass production mode, fabric range also expanded: from *Khaddar* to fabrics including chiffon, chinnon chiffon, georgette, crepe, silk, cotton voile, lizzy bizzy, casement etc.

Commercial or mass production on these varied fabrics adapted simple procedures and of these, most significant was printing of motifs before being embroidered. The base colour of the fabric defines the tones to be used for embroidery. For a lighter base colour, embroidery yarn is to be in contrasting colours like red, maroon, green etc. Whereas for a darker base, one of the coloured threads should match the colour of the base fabric to have an appealing effect.

- Timeline (mandatory): Ancient → Colonial → Post-independence → Present

- Influence of government policies, industrialization, or globalization

Post-independence ‘Handloom Board’ and ‘Handicrafts Board’ for encouraging local weavers and artisans all over India in forming cooperatives, bringing the best of indigenous designs out of them.Separate department of Handicrafts were created, Museums exhibiting rare specimens of embroidery were granted space and state support. A commercial arm for promoting ethnic crafts in the form of state emporiums was established in the commercial hub of the capital city Delhi. Presidential awards were announced for master craft persons from different fields at regular intervals.

Government of India in the year 1952 established ‘The All India Handicrafts Board’. This board promoted handicrafts through interventions like many popular exhibitions and fairs at district, state and national level which provide a strong platform for craftsmen to sell their wares from various parts of India like *Surajkund crafts mela*, Haryana; *Kala Ghoda* Art Festival, Mumbai; *Pushkar Camel Fair*, Rajasthan etc. Creation of new markets has also helped in the revival of craft In addition to these annual exhibitions, government has also started several nodal avenues meant for exclusive sale of handicrafts and to encourage artisans to sell their products directly to the customers like *Dilli Haat, Dastkaar Bazaars* etc. Another external intervention made by the state to further the process of commoditization, purportedly to protect artisans interest through the agency of Self-Help Groups.

These groups are made by various organizations like KVIC, NABARD, Ministry of Textiles etc. In many cases NGOs are involved in creating awareness; some of them are entrusted with the task of motivating artisans especially those belonging to low income groups to voluntarily become part of Self-Help Groups. Members of these groups work together under the guidance of a counselor that helps not only with designs and ideas but also facilitates sale of the products made by them and it provides livelihood and financial independence to these women.

3. Manpower

- Number of families/artisans currently involved
- Comparison with past (10–20 years ago)
- Gender-wise and age-wise participation
- Skill levels (master artisans, helpers, trainees)
- Average income per household (range)
- Livelihood dependency (% income from this craft)
- Reasons for increase/decrease in workforce
- Migration trends (if any)
- Key challenges faced by artisans

Based on the visit to Mehar Baba Charitable Trust, Phulkari Makers in Bassi Pathana, several key challenges faced by artisans were identified. One major issue is the shift in raw materials from

traditional mulberry silk threads to cheaper rayon, which affects the authenticity and overall quality of Phulkari. Similarly, the selection of base fabrics has changed from handwoven khaddar to alternatives like Chanderi and even denim, leading to variations in texture and traditional appeal. Another significant challenge is related to dyeing practices, particularly problems of colour bleeding, which impact the durability and finish of the final product. These challenges highlight the tension between maintaining traditional methods and adapting to cost and market demands.

- Expectations/aspirations of the community

4. GI tag

- Why GI tag given

Phulkari received a GI tag to protect its cultural heritage, ensure authenticity, and prevent imitation of this traditional embroidery that originates from the Punjab region. The GI tag legally recognizes that genuine Phulkari is closely linked to the skills, traditions, and geographical conditions of Punjab, where it has been practiced for generations, especially by rural women. It also helps artisans gain economic benefits and preserves the identity of this indigenous craft.

- Unique features

Phulkari is distinguished by its unique handcrafted embroidery technique, where patterns are created using a darning stitch worked from the reverse side of handwoven khaddar fabric. It uses brightly colored untwisted silk threads (pat), giving the embroidery a rich and vibrant appearance. The designs are inspired by nature, daily life, and Punjabi folklore, often forming geometric and floral patterns. A notable feature is the dense style of embroidery, especially in *Bagh*, where the fabric surface is almost completely covered. Deeply rooted in the cultural traditions of Punjab, Phulkari holds strong social significance, particularly in weddings and festivals, making it a distinctive and region-specific craft worthy of GI recognition.

- Specify the GI Tag document no.

Phulkari, a traditional embroidery art form from Punjab, was officially granted a GI tag on 21st October 2010, following a five-year legal battle led by the Punjab Small Scale Industries & Export Corporation Ltd. The GI tag not only highlights the cultural and artisanal significance of Phulkari in Punjab but also acknowledges its relevance to neighboring states like Haryana and Rajasthan, where similar embroidery traditions are practiced. Phulkari was granted a GI tag because of its unique traditional technique, cultural identity, and strong geographical linkage to Punjab**,** which distinguish it from other embroidery styles and make it worthy of legal protection.

5. Manufacturing steps

- Detailed manufacturing process with a flowchart and images.

Contemporary Phulkari is prepared with a range of material. The fabric used as a base fabric vary from heavy Khaddar to flimsy chiffon or transparent organza or kota doria. In contrast to home spun and hand-woven cloth in the past, these textiles to be used as a base are now acquired from the market. The yarn used in contemporary form is untwisted silken yarn referred to as 'Pat' though synthetic in nature. The motifs remain geometrical in nature as in the traditional form of Phulkari and Baghs. Embroidering technique has evolved and the task of embroiderer is considerably easier because the motifs are now printed by the printers. This method entails the use of carved wooden blocks with etched Phulkari motifs. The base fabric is placed on a printing table and a carved wooden block is dipped in the colour poured on a stamp pad before being put or stamped on the cloth in the desired place or layout. The usage of several motifs or blocks in different layouts lead to a diverse set of designs.

Another method of transferring designs involves the use of tracing paper. The design is first traced onto the tracing paper and then perforated along the outlines. The prepared tracing paper is placed over the base fabric and secured in position. A cloth dipped in colour is gently rubbed over the surface of the tracing paper, allowing the pigment to pass through the perforations and transfer the design onto the fabric.

Women embroider from the right side of the fabric taking help of the outline of the motifs printed on the base fabric. Many of them use an embroidery frame to stretch the cloth. Darning stitch with either a single or double untwisted floss yarn creates a soft embroidered look. Other than darning, herringbone, fishbone, chain stitch etc are also used in preparing Phulkari.

In the present times, women embroider it for personal use as well as for the market. As this art has become more commercialized, the colour choices are made by designers or buyers, rather than by the craftswomen. Traditionally, Phulkari was prepared using contrast or vibrant colour schemes, but current Phulkari pieces also display monochromatic and light colour schemes in addition to contrast colour schemes.

- How much raw materials are used per saree
- Where the raw materials are sourced
- How much energy is utilized in each process
- Form of energy- wood/coal/solar

6. Real photos of Cluster /Product/manufacturing process (Geo tagged if possible)

Process of Phulkari formation at Mehar Baba Charitable Trust, Phulkari Makers, Bassi Pathana

7. Videos (Short clips of weavers describing their journey)

8. Technological Intervention

Technological interventions in Phulkari have enhanced both quality and market reach while preserving its traditional essence. Some key aspects for the technical interventions are as follow.

- Fibre and Yarn-Level Interventions
- Fabric Structure and Construction
- Dyeing and Colour Science Interventions
- Digital Textile Technology Integration
- Testing, Standards and Quality Control

At the fibre and yarn level, improved spinning techniques and stronger silk threads (pat) ensure better durability and finish since shifting in raw materials from traditional mulberry silk threads to cheaper rayon. In fabric construction, refined khaddar weaving and blended fabrics provide consistency and ease of embroidery. Advances in dyeing and colour science, including the use of eco-friendly and colorfast dyes, have improved brightness and longevity of colours. Digital textile technologies such as CAD-based pattern design and e-commerce platforms have expanded design possibilities and market access. Additionally, testing, standardization, and quality control measures ensure uniformity, authenticity, and compliance with national and international textile standards, strengthening Phulkari's position in modern markets.

New technologies in yarn treatment, weaving, printing, eco-friendly dyes, water conservation in the process, sustainable practices etc.